Humayun's reign had only 'scraps of bread'. Forget the men, Akbar himself had suffered such indignities! One of Bairam's men had refused Akbar's orders, another 'replied so rudely to us that he should have had his tongue cut out', a third 'said such an impolite thing' he should have lost his life.

Some of these grudges sprang from court animosities as much as from Akbar's bitter memories. Akbar's letter begins, for example, with a complaint against Shaikh Gada'i, at whose parties Akbar was a regular, presumably happy guest. Now, however, he complained that the shaikh was so favoured by Bairam that he would not even bow to Akbar but come to him on horseback and shake his hand – and, moreover, 'was set above all the sayyids of true lineage'. Resentment against the Shia shaikh in a largely Sunni court was strong. Badauni writes of how other, less favoured clerics went 'mourning from house to house' at Gada'i's elevation, while 'the princes and nobles of the kingdom . . . flew into a rage at [his] advancement', composing disgruntled verse to vent their feelings, as for example: 'Mention not Gada-i's name, eat not his bread.'

Bread, metaphorically speaking, was as much a cause for contention between these factions as faith – Gada'i was appointed *sadr*, chief justice, and had immense power to give out grants of land. So, of course, had Bairam, and again it may have been the mutterings of unhappy chiefs that made Akbar write about the regent favouring his nephew, Husain Quli, with rich fiefs, though Husain Quli had never so much as 'fought . . . a chicken', while 'great khans [had] to make do with ravaged lands'.

Still, Akbar might have disregarded it all – 'you were dear to us,' he said, 'we . . . relied absolutely on your word and deed' – until he heard that Bairam was planning to take away his closest companions. Was this a reference to Maham? Had she said to him, Bairam will banish me across the ocean, and then, one by one, drive away all those you love? Bairam 'intended to deprive us of the few people who accompany us and leave us alone and unattended', said Akbar – and there is a terrible frailty in the words. What is a king without supporters, a boy without his mothers?

But Akbar was not alone; he would not be threatened, nor told what to do. '[W]e have sought to please you over the last five years and not quarrelled with you', he said, but now, 'you will hear and obey this command of ours'. If not, there was no doubt: 'we will crush you'.[101]